The Melancholy Death of Oyster Boy & Other Stories

By Tim Burton

The Robot Boy

Mr. and Mrs. Smith had a wonderful life.
They were a normal, happy husband and wife.
One day they got news that made Mr. Smith glad.
Mrs. Smith would be a mom
which would make him the dad!

But something was wrong with their bundle of joy.
It wasn't human at all,
it was a robot boy!

He wasn't warm and cuddly
and he didn't have skin.
Instead there was a cold, thin layer of tin.
There were wires and tubes sticking out of his head.
He just lay there and stared,
not living or dead.

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INTRODUCTION

In this collection, Tim Burton – the creative genius behind Edward Scissorhands, Sleepy Hollow and Nightmare Before Christmas, gives birth to a cast of gruesomely sympathetic children: misunderstood outcasts who struggle to find love and belonging in their cruel, cruel worlds. What Burton's sad kids all have in common are their bizarre differences.

*But the characters in these poems who are **truly** terrifying are humans, determined to destroy anything that is different. In many ways, the Oyster Boy universe reflects our own world: a place where innocence disappears too easily. As you listen to the seemingly childish verses, think about one thing: Who are the real monsters here?*

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The Melancholy Death of Oyster Boy

He proposed in the dunes,
they were wed by the sea,
Their nine-day-long honeymoon
was on the isle of Capri.

For their supper they had one spectacular dish-
a simmering stew of mollusks and fish.
And while he savored the broth,
her bride's heart made a wish.

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That wish came true-she gave birth to a baby.
But was this little one human
Well, maybe.

Ten fingers, ten toes,
he had plumbing and sight.
He could hear, he could feel,
but normal?
Not quite.

This unnatural birth, this canker, this blight,
was the start and the end and the sum of their plight.

She railed at the doctor:
"He cannot be mine.
He smells of the ocean, of seaweed and brine."

"You should count yourself lucky, for only last week,
I treated a girl with three ears and a beak.
That your son is half oyster
you cannot blame me.
. . . have you ever considered, by chance,
a small home by the sea?"

Not knowing what to name him,
they just called him Sam,
or sometimes,
"that thing that looks like a clam"

Everyone wondered, but no one could tell,
When would young Oyster Boy come out of his shell?

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When the Thompson quadruplets espied him one day,
they called him a bivalve and ran quickly away.

One spring afternoon,
Sam was left in the rain.
At the southwestern corner of Seaview and Main,
he watched the rainwater as it swirled
down the drain.

His mom on the freeway
in the breakdown lane
was pounding the dashboard-
she couldn't contain
the ever-rising grief,
frustration,
and pain.

"Really, sweetheart," she said
"I don't mean to make fun,
but something smells fishy
and I think it's our son.
I don't like to say this, but it must be said,
you're blaming our son for your problems in bed."

He tried salves, he tried ointments
that turned everything red.
He tried potions and lotions
and tincture of lead.
He ached, and he itched and he twitched and he bled.

The doctor diagnosed,
"I can't quite be sure,
but the cause of the problem may also be the cure.
They say oysters improve your sexual powers.
Perhaps eating your son
would help you for hours!"

He came on tiptoe,
he came on the sly,
sweat on his forehead,
and on his lips-a lie.

"Son, are you happy? I don't mean to pry,
but do you dream of Heaven?
Have you ever wanted to die?

Sam blinked his eye twice.
but made no reply.
Dad fingered his knife and loosened his tie.

As he picked up his son,
Sam dripped on his coat.
With the shell to his lips,
Sam slipped down his throat.

They buried him quickly in the sand by the sea
-sighed a prayer, wept a tear-
and they were back home by three.

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A cross of gray driftwood marked Oyster Boy's grave.
Words writ in the sand
promised Jesus would save.

But his memory was lost with one high-tide wave.

*****

Mummy Boy

He wasn't soft and pink
with a fat little tummy;
he was hard and hollow,
a little boy mummy.

"Tell us, please, Doctor,
the reason or cause,
why our bundle of joy
is just a bundle of gauze."

"My diagnosis," he said
"for better or worse,
is that your son is the result
of an old pharaoh's curse."

That night they talked
of their son's odd condition-
they called him "a reject
from an archaeological expedition."

They thought of some complex
scientific explanation,
but assumed it was simple
supernatural reincarnation.

With the other young tots
he only played twice,
an ancient game of virgin sacrifice.
(But the kids ran away, saying, "You aren't very nice.")

alone and rejected, Mummy Boy wept,
then went to the cabinet
where the snack food was kept.

He wiped his wet sockets with his mummified sleeves,
and sat down to a bowl of sugar-frosted tanna leaves.

One dark, gloomy day,
from out of the fog,
appeared a little white mummy dog.

For his newfound wrapped pet,
he did many things,
like building a doghouse
à la Pyramid of kings.

It was late in the day-
just before dark.
Mummy Boy took his dog
for a walk in the park.

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The park was empty
except for a squirrel,
and a birthday party for a Mexican girl.

The boys and girls had all started to play,
but noticed that thing that looked like a papier mâché.

"Look it's a píñata,"
said one of the boys,
"Let's crack it wide open
and get the candy and toys."

They took a baseball bat
and whacked open his head.
Mummy Boy fell to the ground;
he finally was dead.

Inside of his head
were no candy or prizes,
just a few stray beetles
of various sizes.

*****

Anchor Baby

There was a beautiful girl
who came from the sea.
And there was just one place
that she wanted to be.

With a man named Walker
who played in a band.
She would leave the ocean
and come onto the land.

He was the one that she wanted the most.
And she tried everything
to capture this ghost.

But throughout all their lives
they never connected.
She wandered the earth
alone and rejected

She tried looking happy
she tried looking tragic,
she tried astral projecting,
and [you know] black magic.

Nothing could join them,
except maybe one thing,
just maybe . . .
something to anchor their spirits . . .
They had a baby.

But to give birth to a baby
they needed a crane.
the umbilical cord
was in the form of a chain.

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It was ugly and gloomy,
and as hard as a kettle.
It had no pink skin,
just heavy gray metal.

The baby that was meant to bring them together,
just shrouded them both
in a cloud of foul weather.

So Walker took off
to play with the band.
And from that day on,
he stayed mainly on land.

And she was alone
with her gray baby anchor,
who got so oppressive
that eventually sank her.

As she went to the bottom,
not fulfilling her wish,
it was her, and her baby . . .
and a few scattered fish.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tim Burton
ISBN: 978-0688156817
Publisher: Harper Collins
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1997

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier

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